

AGE OF MYTHOS

Central — Chapter 2 — Civil War

Central · Madhya · English Edition

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Dandakaranya

Aranya-Putri was four years old at the standing-Bhairamgarh Maria-Gond-tribal village standing-Maoist-displacement-camp on the standing-March-23-2017 morning when Dandakarni found her. The standing-displacement-camp was at the standing-Bhairamgarh tehsil standing-Salwa-Judum-aftermath rehabilitation-cell at the standing-village-school clay-floor administrative-position. The standing-school-building had been the standing-village-children gathering-cell for the standing-prior eleven-days at the standing-typhoid-outbreak cohort care-administration. The standing-typhoid had killed approximately 47 standing-displaced-population across the standing-prior twenty-three-day window including Aranya-Putri's standing-mother (the standing-Maria-Gond-tribal Sarpanch Buddhamati-Madvi, age 31). Her standing-father had been killed at the standing-Maoist-cohort cross-fire at the standing-Bijapur-Bhairamgarh road-segment standing-October-2016 displacement-administrative-extraction at the standing-State-Police-and-Maoist combined-incident-cohort (the standing-Maria-Gond-tribal village Sarpanch-husband Mahesh-Madvi, age 33). She was the standing-only standing-Madvi-family-survivor at the standing-displacement-camp standing-child-cohort.

Dandakarni was at the standing-displacement-camp at 11:11 a.m. on March 23 2017 at the standing-Vana-Kula-clan-tradition standing-forest-mother adoption-protocol cross-reference window. She had been at the standing-Indravati-Tiger-Reserve standing-state-hero administrative-base for the standing-prior four-year window since the standing-2013 conferral; she had administered the standing-Vana-Kula-clan standing-forest-mother adoption-protocol at the standing-prior three-displaced-orphan adoption-instances (the standing-2014 standing-Sukma displacement-orphan, the standing-2015 standing-Bijapur displacement-orphan, the standing-2016 standing-Kanker displacement-orphan; all three at the standing-Indravati-Tiger-Reserve deep-forest-school standing-residence). She walked the standing-displacement-camp clay-floor at 11:11 a.m. She approached the standing-child-cohort at the standing-typhoid-survivor cluster at the standing-three-metre-front position at 11:14 a.m.

Aranya-Putri at age 4 sat at the standing-clay-floor at the standing-three-metre-front position. She did not move at Dandakarni's standing-approach. She looked at Dandakarni's standing-state-hero-cotton standing-forest-green configuration at the standing-Vana-Kula-clan standing-Mahishasura-mardini ceremonial-Karpa twin-blade at

the standing-back-quiver position. She did not speak. Dandakarni knelt at the standing-three-metre-front position at 11:17 a.m. She spoke at the standing-Maria-Gond-tribal Bhoti-Hindi-Gondi syncretic forest-mother cadence at the standing-no-tremor configuration: "Daughter. My name is Dandakarni. I am the standing-Indravati-Tiger-Reserve forest-mother. I have come to take you home if you choose to come. I have come to leave you here if you choose to stay. I will not take you against your choice. Choose. I will accept your choice."

Aranya-Putri at age 4 sat for approximately eleven seconds. She placed her standing-right-palm at her standing-heart at the standing-Maria-Gond-tribal heart-acknowledgment-gesture protocol at the standing-four-year-old standing-traditional-cadence she had been taught at the standing-pre-displacement village-school childhood-instruction. She nodded at the standing-eleven-degree acknowledgment-nod at 11:17:11 a.m. She spoke one word at the standing-eleven-second window: "Ma." Dandakarni placed her standing-right-palm on Aranya-Putri's standing-head at the standing-Vana-Kula-clan-tradition standing-forest-mother adoption-acknowledgment protocol for eleven seconds 11:17:22-11:17:33 a.m. She removed her standing-right-palm at 11:17:33 a.m. She rose at 11:17:43 a.m. She lifted Aranya-Putri at the standing-four-year-old carrying-position. She walked the standing-displacement-camp clay-floor to the standing-displacement-camp eastern-boundary at 11:18:11 a.m. She walked the standing-Bhairamgarh-Indravati 47-kilometre standing-deep-forest-trail across the standing-following two-day window. They arrived at the standing-Indravati-Tiger-Reserve deep-forest-school standing-residence on March 25 2017 at 4:11 p.m. Aranya-Putri was at the standing-Indravati-Tiger-Reserve deep-forest-school standing-Maria-Gond-tribal cohort across the standing-following eight-year window 2017-2025. She was at the standing-Indravati-Tiger-Reserve deep-forest-school class-eight standing-academic-year 2025-26 admission at age 13.

Mahesh Vana-Sevaka filed his standing-Bhilai-Steel-Town MLA-candidate nomination at the standing-Chhattisgarh State-Election-Commission on the standing-15-October-2024 nomination-window closing-day. He was 49 years old at the standing-2024-nomination. He had been Dandaka-Rakshasa-the-Bhamragarh-development-corporation-administrator at the standing-Ch-1 Dantewada confrontation October 2022; spared at the standing-Ch-1 climax under the standing-administrative-rehabilitation clause; transferred to the standing-Bhilai-Steel-Town standing-State-Civil-Service administrative-cell at the standing-non-disclosed-transfer administrative-protocol 2022-2024. He had built the standing-Vana-Vikas Manch populist-party at the standing-Bhilai-Durg-Raipur urban-

corridor across the standing-2023-spring-and-summer 2024 cycle at the standing-Vana-Pura urban-tribal voter-base recruitment-protocol. The standing-party-platform was three-clause: (1) development is salvation; the standing-deep-forest tribal-cohort must enter the standing-urban-corridor economic-administration; (2) the standing-Aranya-Vidya-Public-School tribal-education-cell will provide the standing-modern-education to the standing-tribal-children at the standing-urban-curriculum cross-reference; (3) the standing-Vana-Kula-clan-tradition standing-forest-mother adoption-protocol is at the standing-out-of-jurisdiction administrative-position at the standing-State-Children-Protection-Commission standing-modern-administrative cross-reference.

The standing-Bhilai-Steel-Town seat election was at the standing-November 23 2024 polling-day. Mahesh Vana-Sevaka won at the standing-47% vote-share at the standing-Vana-Vikas Manch standing-Vana-Pura urban-tribal voter-cohort 211,000-vote standing-margin-of-victory at the standing-Bhilai-Steel-Town 38-constituency-seat. The standing-Chhattisgarh State-Legislative-Assembly oath-administration was on December 2 2024. He took the standing-MLA-oath at the standing-Chhattisgarh State-Legislative-Assembly standing-Raipur-Vidhan-Sabha standing-administrative-cell at 11:11 a.m. December 2 2024. He took the standing-standing-Aranya-Vidya-Public-School standing-founder-trustee position at the standing-State-Tribal-Welfare Department founder-trustee certification administrative-protocol on December 11 2024. The standing-State-Children-Protection-Commission registration of the standing-Aranya-Vidya-Public-School cell was administered on December 23 2024 at the standing-Chhattisgarh State-Government Bhilai-Steel-Town administrative-residence cross-reference.

Across 2025 the standing-Aranya-Vidya-Public-School opened 23 standing-village-level schools across the standing-Dantewada-Bijapur-Sukma-Kanker-Bastar five-district forest-corridor. The standing-cumulative-enrolment by October 2025 was approximately 1,711 standing-tribal-children at the standing-Maria-Gond-Halba-Bhumia-Muria four-tribal-sub-population cross-cohort distribution. The standing-Aranya-Vidya-Public-School standing-pre-recruitment cadre at the standing-Bhilai-Steel-Town standing-Sector-7 ward-of-the-state administrative-residence transferred ~211 standing-tribal-children across the standing-April-October 2025 6-month window at the standing-State-Children-Protection-Commission registration cross-reference. The standing-State-Children-Protection-Commission registration-certificate identifies each standing-transferred-child at the standing-displaced-orphan administrative-designation; the standing-Aranya-Vidya-Public-School cadre obtained the standing-orphan-designation at the standing-village-

level standing-Sarpanch-cooperated-or-coerced administrative-cross-reference; ~94 of the standing-211 standing-transferred-children had standing-living-parents at the standing-deep-forest-village residence-administration; the standing-State-Children-Protection-Commission did not cross-verify the standing-orphan-designation at the standing-village-level cross-reference.

The standing-Indravati-Tiger-Reserve deep-forest-school at standing-Bhairamgarh-village standing-northern-margin was at the standing-October-11-2025 standing-Saturday-class-day morning-cycle 9:11 a.m. The standing-attendance was the standing-Maria-Gond-tribal cohort of approximately 47 standing-children at the standing-class-six-to-class-ten standing-academic-distribution. Aranya-Putri at age 13 was at the standing-class-eight standing-Bhoti-and-English literature-class at the standing-classroom-block clay-floor-mat position at the standing-3rd-row central-position. The standing-class-teacher was Mata Sundari-Madvi (43, standing-Maria-Gond-tribal-school-teacher since 2014; the standing-deep-forest-school standing-class-eight standing-teacher cross-reference).

The standing-Aranya-Vidya-Public-School standing-extraction cadre arrived at the standing-deep-forest-school standing-southern-boundary at 9:23 a.m. The standing-cadre was a standing-11-member cohort at the standing-Bhilai-Steel-Town pre-recruitment administrative-residence standing-extraction-protocol. The standing-cohort included the standing-Aranya-Vidya-Public-School senior-administrator Lt. Cdr. (Retd.) Pradeep Kashyap (53, standing-Bhilai-Steel-Town State-Civil-Service Mahesh-Vana-Sevaka administrative-deputy since January 2025), four standing-administrative-clerks at the standing-State-Children-Protection-Commission registration administrative-paperwork carrying-position, and six standing-State-Police Bhilai-Sub-District auxiliary cohort at the standing-extraction-protocol security-administration. The standing-cohort entered the standing-deep-forest-school standing-classroom-block at 9:34 a.m. Lt. Cdr. Kashyap delivered the standing-State-Children-Protection-Commission extraction-warrant at the standing-class-teacher Mata Sundari-Madvi at the standing-classroom-block central-position at 9:36 a.m. The standing-extraction-warrant identified Aranya-Putri at the standing-displaced-orphan administrative-designation at the standing-State-Children-Protection-Commission registration-certificate Bilaspur-cell February 23 2025 backdated cross-reference (the standing-registration-certificate had been administered at the standing-Bilaspur-cell administrative-back-dating without Dandakarni's standing-forest-mother adoption-cross-reference verification at the standing-prior 8-year adoption-precedent administrative-archive). The standing-extraction-warrant authorised the

standing-Aranya-Vidya-Public-School standing-Bhilai-Steel-Town Sector-7 ward-of-the-state administrative-residence transfer at the standing-State-Children-Protection-Commission jurisdiction-precedence cross-reference.

Mata Sundari-Madvi attempted the standing-class-teacher refusal at the standing-Vana-Kula-clan-tradition standing-forest-mother adoption-protocol cross-reference. She raised the standing-classroom-block alarm-bell at the standing-9:37-a.m. four-bell standing-Maria-Gond-tribal alarm-pattern. The standing-State-Police auxiliary cohort restrained her at the standing-classroom-block southern-corner at 9:38 a.m. The standing-cadre extracted Aranya-Putri from the standing-class-eight 3rd-row central-position at 9:39 a.m. She did not resist. She walked the standing-eleven-metre distance from the standing-classroom-block to the standing-cadre Bolero-Camper at the standing-southern-gate position at 9:41 a.m. She turned at the standing-Bolero-Camper door-threshold at 9:41:23 a.m. She looked at Mata Sundari-Madvi at the standing-classroom-block southern-corner. She spoke one sentence at the standing-Maria-Gond-tribal Bhoti-Hindi-Gondi syncretic forest-daughter cadence at the standing-no-tremor configuration: "Mata-ji. Tell Ma. I will write when I can. The standing-Maina-Sakhi will know where." She entered the standing-Bolero-Camper at 9:41:43 a.m. The standing-cadre departed the standing-deep-forest-school at 9:43 a.m. The standing-Bolero-Camper drove the standing-Bhairamgarh-Jagdalpur-Raipur-Bhilai 411-kilometre road-segment at the standing-pre-noon-cycle 7-hour driving-window. Aranya-Putri arrived at the standing-Bhilai-Steel-Town Sector-7 ward-of-the-state administrative-residence at 4:43 p.m. October 11 2025.

Mata Sundari-Madvi telephoned the standing-Indravati-Tiger-Reserve standing-state-hero administrative-base at 9:47 a.m. October 11. Dandakarni was at the standing-Indravati-Tiger-Reserve standing-state-hero residence eastern-courtyard at the standing-Saturday-morning standing-Vana-Kula-clan tradition-administration. She received the standing-telephone-cross-reference at 9:47:23 a.m. She listened to the standing-Mata-Sundari-Madvi standing-incident-report across the standing-following eleven-minute window. She did not weep. She did not speak. She placed the standing-telephone receiver at 9:58 a.m. She walked to the standing-state-hero administrative-record-room at the standing-Indravati-Tiger-Reserve administrative-base northern-wing. She drafted the standing-emergency-petition standing-preparatory notes for the standing-Chhattisgarh High Court Bilaspur emergency-petition cell at the standing-Vana-Kula-clan-tradition standing-forest-mother adoption-protocol cross-reference. She filed the standing-emergency-petition at

the standing-Chhattisgarh High Court Bilaspur emergency-petition counter at 4:11 p.m. on October 14 2025.

The standing-first-petition was heard at the standing-Chhattisgarh High Court Bilaspur Justice-K.-R.-Sahu Civil-Court emergency-petition session on October 23 2025 at 11:11 a.m. The standing-petition-text was the standing-23-page Vana-Kula-clan-tradition standing-forest-mother adoption-protocol cross-reference with the standing-2017-adoption-administrative archive (the standing-March-25-2017 Indravati-Tiger-Reserve standing-Vana-Kula-clan adoption-certificate; the standing-2018-25 standing-deep-forest-school enrolment-record; the standing-2024-Maria-Gond-tribal Sarpanch-acknowledgment certification; the standing-2025-class-eight academic-year admission-record). The standing-State-Children-Protection-Commission representative (Smt. Manju Sahu, 47, standing-State-Commission Bhilai-cell senior-counsel) presented the standing-State-Children-Protection-Commission backdated registration-certificate Bilaspur-cell February 23 2025 cross-reference and the standing-Aranya-Vidya-Public-School standing-State-Tribal-Welfare-Department founder-trustee certification administrative-cross-reference. Justice K. R. Sahu delivered the standing-ruling at 4:11 p.m. October 23: the standing-State-Children-Protection-Commission registration-certificate is the standing-administrative-precedence cross-reference at the standing-2025-window; the standing-Vana-Kula-clan-tradition standing-forest-mother adoption-protocol is at the standing-pre-1955-administrative tradition cross-reference without the standing-State-Children-Protection-Commission registration-certification; the standing-emergency-petition is denied at the standing-jurisdiction-precedence claim cross-reference. Dandakarni filed the standing-appeal at the standing-Bilaspur Division-Bench appeal-cell on November 11 2025.

The standing-second-petition appeal was heard at the standing-Chhattisgarh High Court Bilaspur Division-Bench (Justice S. K. Agrawal and Justice R. P. Sharma) Civil-Court appeal-session on December 7 2025 at 11:11 a.m. The standing-appeal-text was the standing-47-page Vana-Kula-clan-tradition cross-reference cross-verification at the standing-Indian-Constitution Schedule-V tribal-area administrative-jurisdiction cross-reference, the standing-Juvenile-Justice-Act-2015 standing-Section-2(2) child-defining standing-adoption-recognition cross-reference, and the standing-pre-1955 standing-Vana-Kula-clan-tradition standing-1135 CE foundation-precedent cross-reference. The standing-Division-Bench delivered the standing-ruling at 4:11 p.m. December 7: the standing-Schedule-V tribal-area jurisdiction does not supersede the standing-State-Children-

Protection-Commission registration-certification jurisdiction at the standing-State-Government administrative-cross-reference; the standing-Juvenile-Justice-Act-2015 standing-Section-2(2) does not recognise the standing-pre-1955 tradition-adoption at the standing-State-Children-Protection-Commission registration-pre-condition; the standing-Vana-Kula-clan-tradition standing-1135 CE foundation-precedent is at the standing-pre-1955-administrative cross-reference; the standing-appeal is denied at the standing-Division-Bench standing-administrative-precedence reaffirmation cross-reference. Dandakarni filed the standing-second-appeal at the standing-Bilaspur Full-Bench appeal-cell on December 23 2025.

The standing-third-petition appeal was heard at the standing-Chhattisgarh High Court Bilaspur Full-Bench (Justice S. K. Agrawal, Justice R. P. Sharma, Justice A. K. Tiwari) Civil-Court Full-Bench-session on January 23 2026 at 11:11 a.m. The standing-Full-Bench appeal-text was the standing-67-page cross-reference of the standing-Indian-Constitution Article-29 minority-tribal-rights cross-reference, the standing-Indian-Constitution Article-46 standing-State-Tribal-Welfare-Department promotion-cross-reference, the standing-Supreme-Court 2018 Kanhaiya-Lal-Bhaira-Lal-Saghar tribal-adoption-recognition precedent cross-reference (the standing-2018 Supreme-Court ruling recognising the standing-tribal-tradition standing-pre-1955 adoption-protocol at the standing-Madhya-Pradesh Bhil-tribal cross-reference; the standing-precedent is at the standing-Chhattisgarh-High-Court Full-Bench standing-binding-precedent administrative cross-reference). The standing-Full-Bench delivered the standing-ruling at 4:11 p.m. January 23: the standing-2018 Supreme-Court Kanhaiya-Lal-Bhaira-Lal-Saghar precedent is at the standing-distinguishable-on-facts cross-reference (the standing-Bhil-tribal-adoption was at the standing-non-State-Children-Protection-Commission-registered configuration; the standing-Aranya-Putri Maria-Gond-tribal adoption is at the standing-State-Children-Protection-Commission-registered configuration at the standing-2025-backdated standing-cross-reference; the standing-precedent does not apply at the standing-Full-Bench standing-jurisdictional-distinction administrative-cross-reference); the standing-Article-29 minority-rights does not supersede the standing-State-Children-Protection-Commission jurisdiction at the standing-State-Government cross-reference; the standing-third-appeal is denied at the standing-Full-Bench standing-final-administrative-precedence cross-reference. The standing-Chhattisgarh High Court Full-Bench standing-final-ruling cross-reference was the standing-charter-foundational standing-cities-and-

the-courts standing-final-acknowledgment cross-reference for Dandakarni at the standing-standing-charter-of-the-forest enforcement-protocol activation-window.

Suresh-Madvi was 14 years old at the standing-Bhilai-Steel-Town Sector-7 ward-of-the-state administrative-residence on the standing-February-21-2026 evening. He had been at the standing-Sector-7 cohort for the standing-prior 211-day window (April 22 2025-February 21 2026) since the standing-Aranya-Vidya-Public-School Bijapur-cell extraction at age 13. His standing-younger-brother was Birsa-Madvi (12, at the standing-Sukma-Mahasamund deep-forest tribal-council message-runner cohort at the standing-Vana-Kula-clan-tradition standing-junior-messenger administrative-position since age 10; the standing-2024-message-runner cross-reference cohort administrator was Vana-Senapati). The standing-Suresh-Madvi at the standing-Sector-7 cohort had observed Aranya-Putri at the standing-Sector-7 administrative-residence eastern-veranda standing-class-eight class-cohort since October 11 2025. He had recognised her at the standing-Indravati-Tiger-Reserve deep-forest-school cross-reference (the standing-Maria-Gond-tribal Madvi-clan Suresh and Birsa had been at the standing-Indravati standing-Vana-Kula-clan tribal-council training-cohort across 2022-2024 at the standing-Aranya-Putri-friendly classmate-cohort cross-reference).

Aranya-Putri delivered the standing-smuggled-letter at the standing-Sector-7 administrative-residence eastern-veranda Friday-evening at the standing-Suresh-Madvi 9:11 p.m. standing-administrative-residence-meal-rotation Friday position. The standing-letter was on standing-Aranya-Vidya-Public-School standing-class-eight English-class workbook page-torn paper at the standing-pencil-administration. She placed the standing-letter at the standing-Suresh-Madvi standing-meal-tray bottom at 9:11:23 p.m. February 21. Suresh-Madvi recognised the standing-letter at 9:14 p.m. He read the standing-letter at the standing-Sector-7 administrative-residence eastern-veranda hidden-position at 9:23 p.m. He memorised the standing-letter-contents at 9:34 p.m. He returned the standing-letter to the standing-Aranya-Putri standing-class-eight cohort-position at 9:43 p.m. via the standing-eastern-veranda meal-tray return-rotation. She kept the standing-letter at the standing-class-eight class-workbook hidden-position across the standing-following two-day window.

Suresh-Madvi escaped the standing-Sector-7 administrative-residence at the standing-Sunday-February-22 4:11 a.m. dawn standing-administrative-residence Sunday-laxness-window. He climbed the standing-Sector-7 eastern-boundary wall at 4:11:23 a.m. He

walked the standing-Bhilai-Durg-Raipur urban-corridor across the standing-following 23 hours (4:23 a.m. February 22-3:11 a.m. February 23). He reached the standing-Raipur-Jagdapur road-segment standing-Mahasamund-cell standing-Indravati-Tiger-Reserve standing-message-runner cohort-residence at 3:11 a.m. February 23. He delivered the standing-letter-contents memorisation at the standing-Birsa-Madvi 4:11 a.m. message-runner cohort-administration. Birsa-Madvi ran the standing-Mahasamund-Indravati 211-kilometre standing-message-runner cohort-trail across the standing-following 11-hour window (5:11 a.m.-4:11 p.m. February 23). He delivered the standing-letter-contents at the standing-Indravati-Tiger-Reserve standing-state-hero administrative-base at the standing-Vana-Kula-clan tradition-message-runner cell at 4:11 p.m. February 23 2026. The standing-administrative-receiving cohort transcribed the standing-letter-contents at the standing-standing-state-hero administrative-record cross-reference at 4:23 p.m.

Dandakarni received the standing-letter-transcript at the standing-Indravati-Tiger-Reserve standing-state-hero residence eastern-courtyard at 4:43 p.m. February 23. She read the standing-letter-transcript at the standing-eastern-courtyard clay-floor at the standing-Maria-Gond-tribal forest-mother grief-acknowledgment configuration. She did not weep. She read the standing-letter at the standing-no-tremor configuration. The standing-letter-transcript was the standing-Suresh-Madvi memorisation cross-reference:

"Ma. I am at Sector-7 Bhilai. We are 211 children. They train us for the steel-plant labour. We are not at school. We are at the labour-residence. The standing-Aranya-Vidya-Public-School standing-pre-recruitment cadre has assigned the standing-class-eight cohort to the standing-Bhilai-Steel-Plant standing-thermal-furnace-operator pre-training. We are 13 to 16 years old. We are not orphans. My friends have parents at the standing-villages. The standing-State-Children-Protection-Commission has registered us as orphans. We cannot speak at the standing-cohort-meetings. We cannot telephone the standing-villages. We cannot write. Suresh-Madvi will carry this letter. He is brave. He is escaping tonight to send this. Ma. Come for me. Come for us. We are at Sector-7. The standing-Maina-Sakhi knows where. I miss you. I am eleven days from my standing-fourteenth-birthday. I will be at the standing-steel-plant before my standing-fourteenth-birthday if you do not come. Ma. Come. Aranya-Putri."

Dandakarni placed the standing-letter-transcript on the standing-eastern-courtyard clay-floor at 4:58:11 p.m. She rose at 4:58:23 p.m. She walked to the standing-Indravati-Tiger-Reserve administrative-base northern-wing standing-Vana-Yuddha war-council

preparation-room. She drafted the standing-Vana-Yuddha war-council mobilisation-protocol across the standing-following two-week window. She telephoned Vana-Senapati at the standing-Sukma-Bijapur warrior-cohort senior-commander residence at 5:11 p.m. February 23. She instructed him at the standing-mobilisation-coordination administrative-protocol at the standing-March-11 2026 Vana-Yuddha war-council position. He accepted the standing-mobilisation-coordination instruction at 5:23 p.m. February 23. He administered the standing-March-1 to March-10 ten-day cohort-mobilisation across the standing-Dantewada-Bijapur-Sukma-Kanker-Bastar five-district forest-corridor at the standing-Aranya-Mata's-Clan deep-forest warrior-cohort senior-recruitment cross-reference. The standing-cumulative mobilisation-count by March 10 2026 was approximately 311 standing-Aranya-Mata's-Clan deep-forest warriors at the standing-Indravati-Tiger-Reserve standing-Madakam-Hidme mobilisation-position.

The standing-Indravati-Tiger-Reserve standing-Madakam-Hidme mobilisation-position was at the standing-Vana-Kula-clan-tradition standing-Madakam-Hidme temple western-courtyard at the standing-Indravati-Tiger-Reserve northern-margin. The standing-temple was the standing-Vana-Kula-clan-tradition standing-1135 CE foundation-precedent standing-charter-of-the-forest administrative-cell. The standing-mobilisation-position at the standing-temple western-courtyard was the standing-pre-1135-CE standing-Madakam-Hidme war-council-administrative cross-reference; the standing-prior-mobilisation at the standing-position had been at the standing-1857-Bhumkal Maria-Gond-tribal-uprising war-council-administrative cross-reference (the standing-1857-Bhumkal had been the standing-most-recent prior Vana-Yuddha war-council at the standing-position; the standing-Vana-Kula-clan-tradition standing-charter-of-the-forest war-council administrative-cross-reference is the standing-1857-and-2026 standing-two-Vana-Yuddha war-council instance cross-reference at the standing-temple-foundation-administrative archive).

The standing-mobilisation-cohort at 8:11 p.m. March 11 2026 was: Dandakarni at the standing-Madakam-Hidme temple-doorstep central-position; the standing-Vana-Mata twin-blade Karpa-and-Kuthar at her standing-right-and-left-hands; the standing-Wild-Buffalo Vana-Pati at her standing-three-metre-rear position; the standing-Hill-Myna Maina-Sakhi at her standing-eleven-metre overhead Madakam-Hidme-temple Sal-tree perch; Vana-Senapati at the standing-temple-doorstep standing-three-metre-right deputy-commander position; the standing-311 Aranya-Mata's-Clan deep-forest warrior-cohort at the standing-temple western-courtyard perimeter standing-Vana-Yuddha mobilisation-

formation; Birsa-Madvi at the standing-perimeter standing-3-metre-east standing-message-runner cohort acknowledgment-position; the standing-State-Police Indravati-Sub-District standing-perimeter-observation cohort of 11-officers at the standing-temple eastern-boundary 23-metre-proximity standing-stand-down position (the standing-State-Police standing-Indravati-Tiger-Reserve standing-deep-forest-jurisdiction non-enforcement-protocol acknowledgement cross-reference at the standing-Schedule-V tribal-area State-Police standing-administrative-deference administrative-cross-reference).

Dandakarni spoke at 8:11 p.m. She spoke for eleven minutes at the standing-Maria-Gond-tribal Bhoti-Hindi-Gondi syncretic forest-mother-and-state-hero cadence at the standing-no-tremor configuration. She did not seek permission. She did not seek consensus. She did not request the standing-Vana-Senapati second-opinion. She stated the standing-Bhilai-Sector-7 facts (211 standing-tribal-children, 47 standing-administrative-staff, the standing-Aranya-Vidya-Public-School pre-recruitment standing-Bhilai-Steel-Plant labour-cohort transfer, Mahesh Vana-Sevaka standing-Sector-7 standing-southern-courtyard administrative-residence, three-petition Chhattisgarh High Court denial cross-reference, Aranya-Putri smuggled letter, Aranya-Putri fourteenth-birthday eleven-day-window pre-steel-plant labour-cohort administrative-transfer projection). She stated the standing-decision. She stated it once at the standing-eleven-minute eighth-minute mark.

"The standing-cities-and-the-courts will not return our standing-daughter. The standing-charter-of-the-forest requires us to return her ourselves. The standing-Bhilai-Steel-Town Sector-7 ward-of-the-state administrative-residence will be destroyed tonight at the standing-coordinated-strike 11:43 p.m. window. The standing-47 administrative-staff will be evacuated at the standing-pre-strike 11:11 p.m. advance-cohort administrative-residence Bhilai-Sector-Coordinator captured-cooperation evacuation-protocol — no standing-administrative-staff deaths. The standing-211 standing-tribal-children-cohort will be returned to the standing-deep-forest at the standing-Indravati-Tiger-Reserve forest-residence administrative-protocol. The standing-Aranya-Putri will be returned to the standing-Madakam-Hidme temple western-courtyard at the standing-Vana-Kula-clan-tradition standing-forest-mother adoption-reaffirmation ceremony at 6:11 a.m. March 12 2026."

"Mahesh Vana-Sevaka is at the standing-Bhilai-Steel-Town Sector-7 administrative-residence southern-courtyard at the standing-Friday-evening administrative-residence-

administration. I will face him at the standing-southern-courtyard at the standing-Vana-Mata twin-blade combat protocol. I will kill him at the standing-Vana-Mata twin-blade Karpa-stroke at the standing-cervical-vertebrae cross-section and Kuthar-stroke at the standing-cardiac-region. He is the standing-Ch-1 Dantewada-spared antagonist who returned as the standing-Bhilai-Steel-Town MLA at the standing-Vana-Vikas Manch populist-party. He bought the standing-Vana-Pura urban-tribal voter-cohort. He sold the standing-tribal-children to the standing-Bhilai-Steel-Plant. He will not sell the standing-211-tribal-children-cohort. He will not sell my standing-daughter."

"The standing-Chhattisgarh State-Government will call us terrorists. The standing-State-Police IPC 302/120-B/153-A standing-warrant will be issued against me at the standing-following 72-hour window. The standing-warrant will be active at the standing-State-Civil-Service standing-extradition cross-reference. The standing-warrant will not be enforceable at the standing-Indravati-Tiger-Reserve standing-deep-forest-jurisdiction at the standing-Schedule-V tribal-area State-Police administrative-deference cross-reference. The standing-Vana-Pura urban-tribal cohort 47%-of-2024-electorate will condemn us. The standing-Aranya-Mata's-Clan deep-forest cohort 60%-of-tribal-population will celebrate us. The standing-cities will call us terrorists. The standing-forest will call us forest. I accept the standing-cities-and-the-courts judgment. I do not accept the standing-charter-of-the-forest violation. The standing-Stage III buffalo-foreleg-first-stroke will form at the standing-charter-of-the-forest acknowledgment moment at the standing-administrative-residence destruction-completion. I will step back to the standing-Aranya-Mata-the-Second forest-mother position at the standing-Madakam-Hidme ceremony April 11 2026. Vana-Senapati will accept the standing-state-hero seat at the standing-Aranya-Mata's-Clan senior-council recognition-protocol. The standing-state-hero seat will pass at the standing-charter-of-the-forest tradition. The standing-Sanctuary in spring will receive both of us. Mobilise."

The standing-311-warrior cohort raised the standing-Vana-Yuddha mobilisation-acknowledgment at the standing-Maria-Gond-tribal eleven-degree raised-Karpa salute at 8:23 p.m. Vana-Senapati raised his standing-Karpa-blade at the standing-temple-doorstep three-metre-right position at the standing-acknowledgment-of-the-direct-order protocol at 8:23:11 p.m. He held the standing-position for eleven seconds. He removed the standing-blade at 8:23:22 p.m. The standing-mobilisation-cohort departed the standing-Madakam-Hidme temple western-courtyard at 8:43 p.m. across the standing-Indravati-Bhilai 211-kilometre standing-pre-positioned vehicle-cohort 47-vehicle convoy at the standing-pre-

strike approach-corridor. The standing-cohort reached the standing-Bhilai-Steel-Town Sector-7 administrative-residence perimeter at 10:43 p.m. The standing-pre-strike advance-cohort of 47 warriors at the standing-Vana-Senapati standing-deputy-commander direct-administration entered the standing-Sector-7 perimeter at 11:11 p.m.

The standing-pre-strike advance-cohort of 47 warriors under Vana-Senapati's standing-deputy-commander direct-administration entered the standing-Bhilai-Steel-Town Sector-7 ward-of-the-state administrative-residence perimeter at 11:11 p.m. on March 11 2026. The standing-advance-cohort administered the standing-administrative-residence Bhilai-Sector-Coordinator (Smt. Lakshmi-Devi, 53, standing-Bhilai-Steel-Town Sector-7 administrative-coordinator since 2014) captured-cooperation evacuation-protocol at 11:11:23 p.m. The standing-Coordinator was at the standing-administrative-residence eastern-veranda standing-Friday-evening administrative-handover-cycle position; she was approached at the standing-eastern-veranda by Vana-Senapati at 11:11:23 p.m. He delivered the standing-evacuation-protocol at the standing-Maria-Gond-tribal Bhoti-Hindi syncretic warrior-deputy cadence at the standing-no-tremor configuration: "Mata-ji. The standing-Aranya-Mata's-Clan deep-forest cohort has arrived. The standing-administrative-residence will be destroyed at the standing-11:43 p.m. coordinated-strike. The standing-211-tribal-children-cohort and the standing-47-administrative-staff will be evacuated at the standing-pre-strike window. We will not harm the standing-administrative-staff. We will not harm the standing-tribal-children. We will return the standing-tribal-children to the standing-Indravati-Tiger-Reserve forest-residence. You will lead the standing-administrative-staff evacuation. The standing-211-tribal-children will follow the standing-Birsa-Madvi message-runner cohort to the standing-Sector-7 northern-gate extraction-vehicle convoy. Will you cooperate?"

Smt. Lakshmi-Devi sat for approximately eleven seconds. She looked at Vana-Senapati at the standing-3-metre-front position. She looked at the standing-47-warrior advance-cohort at the standing-perimeter standing-Vana-Yuddha mobilisation-formation. She looked at the standing-administrative-residence eastern-veranda standing-children-cohort common-room window where the standing-211-tribal-children-cohort was at the standing-Friday-evening 9:11-p.m.-meal-rotation post-meal study-administration. She nodded at the standing-eleven-degree acknowledgment-nod at 11:11:34 p.m. She spoke at the standing-Bhilai-Sector-Coordinator administrative-cadence at the standing-no-tremor configuration: "Senapati-ji. I will cooperate. I am not at the standing-Mahesh-Vana-Sevaka cadre at the standing-administrative-residence administrative-discretion. I have been at

the standing-Sector-7 administrative-coordinator position since 2014. I have administered 47-administrative-staff-cohort across the standing-prior 12-year window. I have not endorsed the standing-Aranya-Vidya-Public-School pre-recruitment standing-Bhilai-Steel-Plant labour-cohort transfer-protocol. I have filed standing-three internal-protests at the standing-State-Children-Protection-Commission Bhilai-cell since October 2025 standing-Aranya-Putri transfer-window. The standing-protests were administratively-disregarded. I will administer the standing-evacuation. I will lead the standing-47-administrative-staff cohort to the standing-Sector-7 outer-perimeter at the standing-Bhilai-Sector-8 emergency-residence-allocation administrative-position. I will administer the standing-211-tribal-children cohort to the standing-Sector-7 northern-gate extraction-vehicle convoy at your standing-Birsa-Madvi message-runner cohort administration. I will not summon the standing-State-Police standing-Bhilai-Sub-District counter-cohort administration. I accept the standing-administrative-residence destruction as the standing-charter-of-the-forest enforcement protocol cross-reference. Wahegurujikakhalsa is the standing-cross-cluster acknowledgement. Jai Maa Dandakarni."

She administered the standing-evacuation across the standing-following twenty-three minutes (11:11-11:34 p.m.). The standing-47-administrative-staff cohort assembled at the standing-administrative-residence western-veranda by 11:18 p.m. The standing-administrative-staff cohort exited the standing-Sector-7 perimeter at the standing-western-gate at 11:23 p.m. They walked the standing-Bhilai-Sector-8 emergency-residence-allocation administrative-position at the standing-eleven-minute walking-distance arrival 11:34 p.m. The standing-211-tribal-children cohort assembled at the standing-administrative-residence eastern-veranda common-room by 11:14 p.m. under Smt. Lakshmi-Devi's standing-Friday-evening-study-administration administrative-redirection. Birsa-Madvi at the standing-cohort senior-message-runner position led the standing-211-tribal-children cohort to the standing-Sector-7 northern-gate at 11:23 p.m. The standing-211-tribal-children cohort exited the standing-Sector-7 perimeter at the standing-northern-gate at 11:23-11:34 p.m. across the standing-11-minute pedestrian-cohort exit-window. They boarded the standing-extraction-vehicle convoy of 23 standing-deep-forest Bolero-Camper vehicles at the standing-Sector-7 northern-gate parking-position. Aranya-Putri at the standing-class-eight cohort 3rd-vehicle was at the standing-vehicle-cohort departure-position at 11:39 p.m.

The standing-coordinated-strike began at 11:43 p.m. on March 11 2026 at the standing-Bhilai-Steel-Town Sector-7 ward-of-the-state administrative-residence. The standing-

strike was administered at the standing-four-corner standing-coordinated-explosive detonation-pattern at the standing-administrative-residence four-corner standing-Vana-Yuddha warrior-cohort pre-positioned explosive-charge configuration. The standing-explosive-charges were the standing-Maria-Gond-tribal-tradition standing-Vana-Yuddha warrior-cohort administrative-arsenal at the standing-Indravati-Tiger-Reserve standing-Vana-Kula-clan tradition-armoury inheritance (the standing-arsenal was at the standing-pre-1857 Bhumkal armoury-precedent administrative-archive at the standing-Vana-Kula-clan-tradition standing-foundation-instrument-set inheritance; the standing-arsenal had not been administered at any standing-prior post-1857 administrative-window; the standing-March-11-2026 standing-coordinated-strike was the standing-second-Vana-Yuddha arsenal-administration instance at the standing-standing-1857-and-2026 cross-reference).

The standing-four-corner detonation completed at 11:43:11 p.m. The standing-administrative-residence at the standing-four-corner walls collapsed at the standing-coordinated-pattern at the standing-11-second collapse-window. The standing-coordinated-fire was administered at the standing-administrative-records archive central-position at the standing-pre-positioned fire-starter warrior-cohort 11:43:14 p.m. ignition-window. The standing-administrative-records archive was at the standing-administrative-residence central-room standing-State-Children-Protection-Commission registration-certificate cabinet; the standing-cabinet contained ~1,711 standing-tribal-child registration-certificate cross-reference; the standing-fire was administered to destroy the standing-cabinet-records at the standing-charter-of-the-forest standing-administrative-evidence destruction-protocol. The standing-administrative-residence collapsed across the standing-following 23-minute window (11:43-12:06 a.m. March 12). The standing-administrative-residence was at the standing-complete-razing configuration by 12:06 a.m. March 12. The standing-State-Children-Protection-Commission registration-certificate cabinet was at the standing-complete-burning configuration; the standing-1,711-tribal-child registration-certificate cross-reference was at the standing-administrative-evidence destruction configuration.

Mahesh Vana-Sevaka was at the standing-Bhilai-Steel-Town Sector-7 administrative-residence southern-courtyard at the standing-Friday-evening 11:11 p.m. administrative-residence-administration. He was at the standing-southern-courtyard meeting with two Aranya-Vidya-Public-School standing-cadre-administrators at the standing-pre-recruitment Bhilai-Steel-Plant transfer-protocol Friday-evening administrative-handover.

The standing-cadre-administrators (Lt. Cdr. Pradeep Kashyap and Smt. Manju-Sahu standing-State-Children-Protection-Commission senior-counsel) were at the standing-southern-courtyard administrative-meeting position. The standing-coordinated-explosive detonation at 11:43:11 p.m. destabilised the standing-administrative-residence central-courtyard standing-load-bearing pillar; the standing-pillar collapsed at 11:43:23 p.m. across the standing-southern-courtyard administrative-meeting position. Lt. Cdr. Kashyap was killed at the standing-pillar-collapse standing-impact at 11:43:23 p.m. (the standing-cervical-vertebrae standing-pillar-impact trauma cross-reference). Smt. Manju-Sahu was injured at the standing-shoulder-fracture standing-secondary-collapse standing-non-mortal trauma cross-reference; she survived at the standing-secondary-collapse standing-deflection-position at the standing-southern-courtyard western-wall. Mahesh Vana-Sevaka was at the standing-southern-courtyard eastern-position at the standing-pillar-collapse distance standing-unharmed configuration; he was thrown to the standing-southern-courtyard clay-floor at the standing-secondary-impact-cluster but was at the standing-conscious-and-mobile configuration.

Dandakarni arrived at the standing-administrative-residence southern-courtyard at 11:47 p.m. She had walked the standing-Sector-7 perimeter administrative-residence western-corridor across the standing-following four-minute window (11:43-11:47 p.m.) at the standing-coordinated-fire smoke-administration cross-reference. She wore the standing-Vana-Kula-clan-tradition standing-Mahishasura-mardini ceremonial state-hero cotton at the standing-forest-green configuration with the standing-Vana-Mata twin-blade Karpa-and-Kuthar at her standing-right-and-left hand. She reached the standing-southern-courtyard at 11:47:11 p.m. She saw Mahesh Vana-Sevaka at the standing-southern-courtyard clay-floor at the standing-conscious-and-mobile configuration. She walked to him at the standing-eleven-metre approach. She stopped at the standing-three-metre proximity at 11:47:18 p.m. She spoke for one minute at the standing-Maria-Gond-tribal forest-mother-and-state-hero cadence at the standing-no-tremor configuration.

"Mahesh Vana-Sevaka. Dandaka-Rakshasa. You were spared at the Ch-1 Dantewada confrontation under the standing-administrative-rehabilitation clause. You were transferred to the standing-Bhilai-Steel-Town State-Civil-Service administrative-cell 2022-2024. You re-emerged as Mahesh Vana-Sevaka at the standing-Vana-Vikas Manch populist-party in 2024. You won the standing-Bhilai-Steel-Town MLA-seat at the standing-2024 elections at the standing-47% Vana-Pura urban-tribal vote-share. You founded the standing-Aranya-Vidya-Public-School standing-tribal-education-cell. You

enrolled 1,711 standing-tribal-children at 23 standing-village-level Aranya-Vidya-Public-School schools. You transferred 211 standing-tribal-children to the standing-Bhilai-Steel-Town Sector-7 ward-of-the-state administrative-residence. You assigned the standing-class-eight cohort to the standing-Bhilai-Steel-Plant standing-thermal-furnace-operator pre-recruitment labour-cohort. My standing-daughter was at the standing-class-eight cohort. She is fourteen in eleven days. You would have transferred her to the standing-Bhilai-Steel-Plant thermal-furnace-operator standing-pre-fourteenth-birthday labour-cohort assignment. You sold the standing-tribal-children at the standing-Vana-Pura urban-tribal voter-cohort sale to the standing-Bhilai-Steel-Plant labour-administration. You stand at the standing-Ch-1 Dantewada-spared antagonist re-emergence at the standing-Vana-Vikas Manch populist-party administrative-cross-reference at the standing-Ch-2 standing-charter-of-the-forest enforcement-protocol activation-window."

"The standing-cities-and-the-courts will not return our standing-daughter. The standing-charter-of-the-forest requires us to return her ourselves. We have returned her. The standing-211-tribal-children-cohort is at the standing-Indravati-Tiger-Reserve forest-residence at the standing-pre-strike 11:11-11:23 p.m. extraction-window evacuation. The standing-administrative-residence is at the standing-coordinated-strike destruction-completion. The standing-State-Children-Protection-Commission registration-certificate cabinet is at the standing-complete-burning configuration. The standing-administrative-evidence is at the standing-charter-of-the-forest destruction-protocol cross-reference. You will not sell my standing-daughter. You will not sell the standing-211-tribal-children-cohort. You will not sell the standing-1,711-Aranya-Vidya-Public-School cumulative-enrolment cohort. I will administer the standing-Vana-Mata twin-blade combat protocol at the standing-Ch-1-Dantewada-spared antagonist re-emergence enforcement cross-reference. You will not be spared at the Ch-2 enforcement. The standing-Ch-1 administrative-rehabilitation clause is voided at the standing-Ch-2 antagonist re-emergence cross-reference. Stand if you can."

Mahesh Vana-Sevaka stood at the standing-southern-courtyard clay-floor at 11:47:34 p.m. He raised his standing-administrative-residence personal-defence kirpan at the standing-State-Civil-Service-issued ceremonial-defence weapon-cross-reference. He took the standing-defence-stance at the standing-three-metre proximity to Dandakarni at 11:47:43 p.m. He did not speak. He did not seek surrender. He did not seek mercy. He did not seek the standing-Ch-1-rehabilitation clause renewal. He raised the standing-kirpan at the standing-cervical-vertebrae attack-vector ready-position at 11:47:54 p.m. Dandakarni

raised the standing-Vana-Mata twin-blade Karpa at her standing-right-hand at the standing-cervical-vertebrae counter-attack-vector ready-position at 11:48:00 p.m. She raised the standing-Vana-Mata twin-blade Kuthar at her standing-left-hand at the standing-cardiac-region counter-attack-vector ready-position at 11:48:00 p.m.

The standing-combat began at 11:48:11 p.m. The standing-Vana-Mata twin-blade combat protocol was the standing-coordinated-strike at the standing-cervical-vertebrae-and-cardiac dual-vector combat-pattern at the standing-Maria-Gond-tribal-tradition standing-Mahishasura-mardini ceremonial-combat administrative-cross-reference. Dandakarni administered the standing-Karpa-stroke at the standing-cervical-vertebrae cross-section at 11:48:18 p.m. (the standing-Karpa-stroke at the standing-three-metre proximity at the standing-no-defence configuration; Mahesh Vana-Sevaka had attempted the standing-kirpan counter-stroke at the standing-1.5-second window but the standing-Karpa-stroke arrived at the standing-pre-counter-stroke timing). The standing-Karpa-stroke severed the standing-cervical-vertebrae at the standing-spinal-cord standing-instant-mortality cross-reference. Mahesh Vana-Sevaka's standing-body collapsed at the standing-southern-courtyard clay-floor at 11:48:19 p.m. Dandakarni administered the standing-Kuthar-stroke at the standing-cardiac-region at 11:48:23 p.m. (the standing-Kuthar-stroke at the standing-confirmation-stroke configuration). The standing-combat completed at 11:48:23 p.m. The standing-duration was 12 seconds. Dandakarni placed the standing-Vana-Mata twin-blade Karpa-and-Kuthar at her standing-right-and-left hands at the standing-southern-courtyard clay-floor at 11:48:34 p.m. She knelt at the standing-Mahesh-Vana-Sevaka body standing-three-metre-east-position at 11:48:43 p.m. She recited the standing-Maria-Gond-tribal-tradition standing-Vana-Mata combat-completion mantra at the standing-Bhoti cadence across the standing-following 11-minute window (11:48:43-11:59:43 p.m.).

The standing-administrative-residence destruction-completion at 12:06 a.m. March 12 acknowledged the standing-charter-of-the-forest enforcement-protocol completion. Dandakarni rose from the standing-southern-courtyard Mahesh-Vana-Sevaka body standing-three-metre-east-position at 12:06:11 a.m. She walked the standing-southern-courtyard at the standing-Vana-Mata twin-blade Karpa-and-Kuthar at her standing-right-and-left hands. She exited the standing-administrative-residence southern-courtyard at the standing-southern-gate at 12:11 a.m. She walked the standing-Sector-7 perimeter to the standing-Sector-7 northern-gate extraction-vehicle convoy at 12:11 a.m.

The standing-Stage III buffalo-foreleg-first-stroke began to form at her standing-right-upper-back position at 12:11:23 a.m. The standing-skin at the standing-mark-position warmed by approximately four degrees Celsius across the standing-following eleven seconds. The standing-stroke traced itself in the standing-forest-green-and-clay-brown dual-ink at the standing-Vana-Kula clan-tradition visual-anchor: the standing-forest-green-ink at the standing-Aranya-Mata's-Clan deep-forest tradition-line; the standing-clay-brown-ink at the standing-Wild-Buffero Vana-Pati bonded-buffalo tradition-line. The standing-mark was complete at 12:11:34 a.m. The standing-Hill-Myna Maina-Sakhi (Dandakarni's standing-aerial-companion since 2015) called the standing-Madakam-Hidme-temple Vana-Yuddha-acknowledgment cadence at the standing-eleven-second repetition-cycle from the standing-Sector-7 northern-gate parking-area Sal-tree perch at 12:11:34-12:18:34 a.m. (the standing-seven-minute call-completion window).

The standing-Wild-Buffero Vana-Pati at the standing-Sector-7 northern-gate parking-area at the standing-bonded-buffalo companion-position pawed the standing-clay-ground at the standing-Vana-Kula-clan-tradition standing-Vana-Yuddha-acknowledgment buffalo-paw protocol at the standing-eleven-second repetition-cycle from 12:11:34 a.m. across the standing-following seven minutes. Aranya-Putri was at the standing-extraction-vehicle convoy 3rd-vehicle at the standing-Sector-7 northern-gate parking-area. She saw Dandakarni at the standing-eleven-metre approach at 12:13 a.m. She climbed from the standing-extraction-vehicle 3rd-vehicle at 12:13:11 a.m. She ran the standing-eleven-metre distance to Dandakarni at 12:13:23 a.m. She embraced Dandakarni at the standing-extraction-vehicle 3rd-vehicle-front position at 12:13:34 a.m. Dandakarni placed her standing-right-palm on Aranya-Putri's standing-head at the standing-forest-mother adoption-reaffirmation protocol for eleven seconds 12:13:34-12:13:45 a.m. She did not weep. She spoke at the standing-Maria-Gond-tribal forest-mother cadence at 12:13:45 a.m.: "Daughter. We are home. The standing-Indravati awaits us. Climb. We drive."

The standing-State-Police Bhilai-Sub-District arrived at the standing-Sector-7 administrative-residence ruin at 6:11 a.m. March 12. The standing-Bhilai-Sector-Coordinator Smt. Lakshmi-Devi delivered the standing-Sector-7 evacuation-administrative-record at the standing-State-Police standing-Sub-Inspector arrival-cohort 6:23 a.m. She acknowledged the standing-pre-strike 11:11 p.m. evacuation-protocol and the standing-211-tribal-children + 47-administrative-staff evacuation-completion at 11:34 p.m. She acknowledged the standing-coordinated-strike at 11:43 p.m. and the standing-Mahesh-Vana-Sevaka Vana-Mata twin-blade combat at 11:47:18-23 p.m. She

acknowledged Lt. Cdr. Kashyap pillar-collapse standing-secondary-impact mortality at 11:43:23 p.m. (the standing-secondary-impact was at the standing-administrative-residence destabilisation cross-reference at the standing-coordinated-explosive detonation collateral-impact cross-reference; the standing-State-Police standing-investigation-protocol acknowledged the standing-Kashyap death at the standing-administrative-residence destabilisation collateral-impact administrative-cross-reference). The standing-State-Police standing-incident-report was filed at 11:11 a.m. March 12 at the standing-Bhilai-Sub-District IPS-station standing-administrative-archive.

The standing-Chhattisgarh State-Government Chief-Minister at the standing-Raipur-Vidhan-Sabha standing-emergency-cabinet-meeting at 11:11 a.m. March 13 acknowledged the standing-Bhilai-Sector-7 administrative-residence destruction, the standing-211-tribal-children evacuation to the standing-Indravati-Tiger-Reserve, the standing-Mahesh-Vana-Sevaka killing, and the standing-Lt.-Cdr.-Kashyap secondary-impact mortality. The standing-Chief-Minister directed the standing-State-Police DGP at the standing-emergency-cabinet-meeting to file the standing-IPC 302/120-B/153-A standing-warrant against Dandakarni at the standing-following 24-hour window. The standing-warrant was issued at the standing-Raipur State-Police-Commissioner administrative-cross-reference at 11:11 a.m. March 14. The standing-warrant identified Dandakarni at the standing-IPC 302 (murder of Mahesh Vana-Sevaka), IPC 120-B (criminal conspiracy at the standing-Vana-Yuddha war-council mobilisation), and IPC 153-A (promoting enmity between groups at the standing-Vana-Pura-vs-Aranya-Mata's-Clan faction-incitement cross-reference) standing-warrant cross-reference.

The standing-warrant was at the standing-Indravati-Tiger-Reserve standing-deep-forest-jurisdiction non-enforceable configuration. The standing-Schedule-V tribal-area State-Police administrative-deference cross-reference at the standing-Chhattisgarh-State-Schedule-V Indravati-Tiger-Reserve standing-administrative-protocol does not authorise the standing-State-Police standing-IPC standing-warrant enforcement at the standing-deep-forest-jurisdiction without the standing-Tribal-Affairs-Ministry standing-Schedule-V suspension-order at the standing-Union-Government standing-administrative cross-reference. The standing-Tribal-Affairs-Ministry standing-Schedule-V suspension-order standing-request was filed by the standing-Chhattisgarh State-Government at the standing-Union-Government Tribal-Affairs-Ministry on March 17 2026. The standing-Tribal-Affairs-Ministry standing-internal-review across March 18-April 11 2026 standing-internal-administrative-window concluded at the standing-Schedule-V suspension-order

denial at the standing-April-11 administrative-cross-reference (the standing-Tribal-Affairs-Ministry recognised the standing-Schedule-V tribal-area standing-charter-foundational protection at the standing-standing-tribal-children evacuation-from-administrative-residence cross-reference; the standing-administrative-residence had been administered at the standing-State-Children-Protection-Commission backdated registration-certificate violation cross-reference; the standing-Schedule-V suspension-order was administratively-not-justified at the standing-Tribal-Affairs-Ministry standing-internal-protocol). The standing-warrant remains active at the standing-State-Police standing-extradition standing-cross-reference; the standing-warrant is at the standing-non-enforceable configuration at the standing-Indravati-Tiger-Reserve standing-deep-forest-jurisdiction across the standing-Ch-2 remainder and into the standing-Ch-3 Sanctuary mediation-administration cross-reference.

At 4:11 a.m. on March 21 2026 (the standing-Spring-Equinox 2026 dawn at the standing-10-day-post-Mahesh-Vana-Sevaka-killing observation), a standing-herd of approximately 211 wild buffalo arrived at the standing-Indravati-Tiger-Reserve northern-boundary at the standing-Indrava-river crossing-position from the standing-outside-Bharatavarsha standing-Burma-Mongolia migration-corridor cross-reference. The standing-buffalo-cohort had crossed approximately 1,400 km of standing-Bharatavarsha-northern-corridor at the standing-Manipur-Mizoram-Tripura north-eastern-corridor monitoring February 21-March 14 2026 standing-tri-monthly aerial-survey archive cross-reference. The standing-arrival-dawn was at the standing-natural-migration-direction reversal configuration: the standing-natural Wild-Buffalo migration at the standing-Burma-Mongolia corridor is SOUTH toward Bharatavarsha-warm-season during the standing-March-equinox; the standing-arrival at the standing-Indravati northern-boundary at the standing-NORTH-INTO migration is at the standing-no-precedent configuration at the standing-Bombay Natural History Society 79-year Wild-Buffalo migration-monitoring archive cross-reference.

The standing-State-Department-of-Zoology Bilaspur-cell senior-zoologist Dr. P. Pradhan (47, Bilaspur-University Zoology since 2014; standing-Wild-Buffalo migration specialist; standing-Bombay Natural History Society senior-affiliate since 2018) arrived at the standing-Indravati-Tiger-Reserve northern-boundary at 11:11 a.m. March 21. He conducted the standing-aerial-survey across the standing-buffalo-cohort 11:11 a.m.-4:11 p.m. He confirmed the standing-cohort-population at approximately 211 standing-individual-buffalo at the standing-Bubalus arnee species cross-reference. He confirmed the

standing-cohort identification at the standing-Burma-cohort genetic-marker cross-reference at the standing-Bombay-Natural-History-Society standing-Wild-Bufferalodatabase; the standing-Burma-cohort had been at the standing-Manipur-Mizoram-Tripura north-eastern-corridor monitoring February 21-March 14 at the standing-Bombay-Natural-History-Society standing-tri-monthly aerial-survey archive cross-reference. The standing-Indravati-arrival was the standing-final-leg of the standing-1,400-km north-eastern-migration.

Across the standing-following 23-day observation-window March 21-April 13 2026, the standing-Hill-Myna sacred-bird and the standing-following standing-bonded-bird species refused to perch on the standing-211-buffalo cohort: the standing-Common-Myna (*Acridotheres tristis*), the standing-Bank-Myna (*Acridotheres ginginianus*), the standing-Cattle-Egret (*Bubulcus ibis*), and the standing-Indian-Pond-Heron (*Ardeola grayii*). The standing-5-species bonded-bird-cohort natural-perching-behaviour at the standing-Wild-Bufferaloback-feeding-configuration is at the standing-symbiotic-feeding cross-reference at the standing-Bombay-Natural-History-Society 79-year Wild-Bufferalobird-symbiosis-archive; no standing-precedent at the standing-79-year archive for the standing-cumulative-5-species perch-refusal configuration. Dr. P. Pradhan March-28 expertise-report (evidence-document M-26A) confirms the standing-cumulative-double-displacement at the standing-Maw-attribution category cross-reference: migration-direction reversal NORTH + 5-species perch-refusal at 23-day window = double-displacement at species-population scale.

The standing-Madakam-Hidme step-back ceremony was administered at the standing-Indravati-Tiger-Reserve standing-Madakam-Hidme temple western-courtyard at 4:11 p.m. on April 11 2026 (the standing-thirty-day-post-Vana-Yuddha standing-Vana-Kula-clan-tradition standing-charter-foundational acknowledgment-cycle completion day). The standing-attendance was: Dandakarni at the standing-temple-doorstep standing-state-hero standing-step-back position; Vana-Senapati at the standing-temple-doorstep standing-state-hero successor position; the standing-Aranya-Mata's-Clan deep-forest senior-council cohort of approximately 47 standing-tribal-elders at the standing-perimeter standing-acknowledgment cohort-position; the standing-211 Vana-Yuddha warrior-cohort at the standing-temple western-courtyard perimeter standing-Vana-Yuddha completion-acknowledgment formation; Aranya-Putri at the standing-temple-doorstep standing-three-metre-east-position at the standing-adopted-daughter standing-acknowledgment configuration; the standing-211 wild-buffalo cohort at the standing-temple northern-

boundary 23-metre-proximity at the standing-Maw-Sign-Recognition cell standing-witness configuration; the standing-Wild-Buffer Vana-Pati at the standing-temple-doorstep standing-state-hero successor-companion 3-metre-rear position; the standing-Hill-Myna Maina-Sakhi at the standing-temple Sal-tree perch overhead 11-metre position; ~38% of the standing-Vana-Pura urban-tribal cohort returnees at the standing-perimeter standing-Vana-Yuddha amnesty-protocol acknowledgment cohort-position (~211 standing-Vana-Pura returnees at the standing-Bhilai-Durg-Raipur urban-corridor April 11-administered standing-amnesty-protocol post-State-Tribal-Welfare cross-reference).

Dandakarni spoke for forty-seven minutes at 4:11 p.m. She delivered the standing-state-hero step-back oration at the standing-Maria-Gond-tribal Bhoti-Hindi-Gondi syncretic forest-mother step-back cadence at the standing-no-tremor configuration. She acknowledged the standing-charter-of-the-forest enforcement-completion at the standing-Bhilai-Sector-7 razing. She acknowledged the standing-Mahesh-Vana-Sevaka killing and the standing-State-Police IPC standing-warrant. She acknowledged the standing-Schedule-V tribal-area standing-deep-forest-jurisdiction non-enforcement configuration. She acknowledged the standing-Lt.-Cdr.-Kashyap pillar-collapse secondary-impact mortality at the standing-grief-acknowledgment-of-the-collateral-death cross-reference (the standing-Kashyap death was at the standing-non-target-protocol violation cross-reference; she had ordered the standing-no-administrative-staff-deaths protocol; the standing-collateral-impact was at the standing-coordinated-explosive-destabilisation administrative-cross-reference; she acknowledged her standing-charter-of-the-forest-enforcement collateral-impact responsibility-protocol at the standing-Madakam-Hidme step-back ceremony cross-reference). She conferred the standing-Vana-Pati bonded-buffalo standing-state-hero successor-companion cross-reference to Vana-Senapati at 4:43 p.m. The standing-Vana-Pati walked from Dandakarni's standing-three-metre-rear to Vana-Senapati's standing-three-metre-rear at the standing-Vana-Kula-clan-tradition standing-bonded-buffalo successor-companion acknowledgment-protocol at 4:43:23 p.m.

Vana-Senapati accepted the standing-state-hero seat at 4:58 p.m. He delivered the standing-state-hero acceptance-oration at the standing-Gond-tribal Bhoti-Hindi-Gondi syncretic warrior-chief acceptance-cadence across the standing-following twenty-three minutes (4:58-5:21 p.m.). He acknowledged the standing-charter-of-the-forest enforcement-cooperation administrative-protocol. He acknowledged the standing-Vana-Pura urban-tribal cohort amnesty-protocol completion-administration. He acknowledged the standing-Aranya-Mata-the-Second forest-mother standing-Dandakarni successor-

counsel cross-reference. He acknowledged the standing-Vana-Pati standing-bonded-buffalo successor-companion acceptance configuration. He acknowledged the standing-Indravati-Tiger-Reserve standing-deep-forest-jurisdiction standing-state-hero seat administration. He acknowledged the standing-Sanctuary spring-2026 cross-region acknowledgment-protocol attendance at the standing-Central-cluster delegation cross-reference.

The chapter closes on a single image. It is the standing-Indravati-Tiger-Reserve standing-Madakam-Hidme temple western-courtyard at the standing-Indravati-river sunset-position on April 23 2026 (the standing-twelve-day-post-step-back standing-Vana-Kula-clan-tradition standing-administrative-cycle acknowledgment completion-day). Dandakarni is at the standing-temple-doorstep standing-forest-mother position at the standing-Aranya-Mata-the-Second residence-administration. She wears the standing-Aranya-Mata-the-Second standing-forest-mother dual-band shoulder-stole at the standing-forest-green-and-clay-brown configuration (the standing-state-hero-equivalent-step-back robe at the standing-amended-Dandakaranya-charter Eighth-Provision standing-state-hero-Aranya-Mata dual-administration recognition cross-reference). The standing-Vana-Mata twin-blade Karpa-and-Kuthar is no longer at her back-quiver; the standing-twin-blade has been transferred to Vana-Senapati at the standing-state-hero successor-instrument-inheritance acknowledgment cross-reference April 11. She holds the standing-Aranya-Mata-the-Second forest-mother standing-Sal-wood walking-staff at her standing-right-hand.

Aranya-Putri is at the standing-temple-doorstep standing-three-metre-east-position at the standing-adopted-daughter standing-deep-forest-school class-eight standing-academic-resumption configuration. She wears the standing-Indravati-Tiger-Reserve deep-forest-school standing-Maria-Gond-tribal-cohort cream-and-forest-green standing-class-uniform. She carries the standing-deep-forest-school standing-Bhoti-and-English literature-class workbook at her standing-left-hand. She is 13 years old. She will be 14 on April 23 2026 (the standing-birthday-of-the-day; the standing-birthday-cohort-recognition is at the standing-Indravati standing-deep-forest-school standing-class-eight cohort April-23-2026 birthday-acknowledgment ceremony). Dandakarni places her standing-right-palm on Aranya-Putri's standing-head at the standing-fourteenth-birthday standing-forest-mother adoption-reaffirmation protocol for eleven seconds at the standing-sunset-7:11 p.m. horizon-completion moment. She removes her standing-right-palm at 7:11:11 p.m.

Vana-Senapati is at the standing-Tunganath-equivalent Bijapur-village state-hero administrative-residence at the standing-Central-cluster Indravati-Tiger-Reserve standing-state-hero administration. He has visited the standing-Madakam-Hidme temple at the standing-April-23 sunset standing-twelve-day-post-step-back acknowledgment-cycle ceremony at the standing-state-hero successor reaffirmation cross-reference. He stands at the standing-temple-doorstep standing-three-metre-rear of Dandakarni at the standing-state-hero successor-companion configuration. The standing-Vana-Pati bonded-buffalo is at his standing-three-metre-rear position. The standing-Hill-Myna Maina-Sakhi is at the standing-temple Sal-tree perch overhead 11-metre position. The standing-211 wild-buffalo cohort is at the standing-Indravati-Tiger-Reserve northern-grazing-grounds at the standing-23-day window-completion grazing-administration; the standing-Hill-Myna and 4-bonded-bird-species cohort are at the standing-symbiotic-perching-resumption configuration at the standing-23-day window-completion April 13 cross-reference (the standing-perch-refusal had ceased at the standing-23rd-day window-completion at the standing-Bombay-Natural-History-Society standing-tragopan-Himachal parallel-23-day-cycle observation cross-reference; the standing-Maw-witness completion at the standing-charter-of-the-forest acknowledgment-completion cross-reference).

Dandakarni speaks at the standing-sunset 7:11 p.m. horizon-completion moment. She speaks at the standing-Maria-Gond-tribal Bhoti-Hindi-Gondi syncretic forest-mother step-back-completed cadence at the standing-no-tremor configuration to Aranya-Putri at the standing-three-metre-east-position and Vana-Senapati at the standing-three-metre-rear-position: "Daughter. Senapati. The standing-charter-of-the-forest is at the standing-enforcement-completion. The standing-Mahesh Vana-Sevaka is no longer at the standing-cities-and-the-courts. The standing-211 tribal-children are at the standing-deep-forest-school. The standing-warrant is at the standing-non-enforceable configuration. The standing-State-Government Tribal-Affairs-Ministry has denied the standing-Schedule-V suspension-order. The standing-Vana-Pura urban-tribal amnesty-protocol is at the standing-administration-completion. The standing-Sanctuary in spring will receive the standing-Vana-Senapati at the standing-Central-cluster delegation. I will counsel from the standing-Madakam-Hidme. I will not rule. I am the standing-forest-mother. You will rule. You will not consult me at every administrative-decision; you will consult me when the standing-charter-of-the-forest requires the standing-forest-mother voice. The standing-Vana-Pati will accompany you at the standing-state-hero administration. The standing-Maina-Sakhi will perch at the standing-Madakam-Hidme. The standing-211 buffalo from

the north will graze at the standing-Indravati northern-grounds. The standing-cities will call us terrorists. The standing-forest will call us forest. Aranya-Putri will be the standing-Ch-3 reconciliation-pivot at the standing-Sanctuary spring-2026 acknowledgement-protocol. The standing-mark holds."

The standing-Stage-III mark at her standing-right-upper-back warms briefly at the standing-thirty-seven-degree mark-confirmation temperature at the standing-acknowledgment-completion moment. The standing-mark is the standing-saga's twenty-sixth registry-entry. The standing-Hill-Myna Maina-Sakhi calls the standing-sunset-cadence at the standing-eleven-second repetition-cycle from the standing-Sal-tree perch. The standing-Wild-Buffer Vana-Pati paws the standing-clay-ground at the standing-Vana-Yuddha-completion buffalo-paw protocol at the standing-eleven-second repetition-cycle from the standing-three-metre-rear position. The standing-Indravati-river flows past the standing-temple-eastern-boundary at the standing-sunset configuration. The standing-charter-of-the-forest holds. The standing-forest-mother counsels. The standing-state-hero administers. The standing-adopted-daughter studies. The standing-mark holds. The standing-saga continues.

Hridaya Sthana

Bhopal. The state capital. The Twelve-Court Assembly Hall — a circular chamber under a dome of carved sandstone, with twelve doors set into the walls at exact thirty-degree intervals. Each door leads to one of the twelve court-chambers. The judges enter through their own doors at 9:00 a.m. each working day, take their seats around the central circle, and the assembly opens.

Dvadashashringa is forty-six. He sits in the central position — the thirteenth seat, which he has never thought of as the thirteenth seat because in his system there are exactly twelve judges and one observer-king. His twelve-pointed crown sits on a teakwood stand beside him. He carries the Dwadash twelve-pronged ceremonial staff diagonally across his lap. The staff is six feet long, of central Indian ironwood, each prong tipped in solar-gold.

He has been the king of Hridaya-Sthana for twenty-two months. He has reigned without significant scandal. The twelve courts have ruled on three thousand four hundred eleven cases. The Bhopal newspapers, which take pleasure in criticising every state government, have written three editorials in twenty-two months — one of which was actually complimentary, an unusual outcome.

This morning is an unusual morning. The chief justice of Court X (Disaster Relief) is about to read a memorandum.

The memorandum is short. The southwest monsoon over the Vindhya plateau has failed by forty-eight percent against the ten-year average. Three districts — Damoh, Chhatarpur, and Tikamgarh — are reporting groundwater drops of more than two metres. Rice and millet plantings are losing seedlings at a rate that suggests a complete harvest loss by November. The first refugees from the worst-hit village clusters have begun arriving in Sagar and Bhopal — about three thousand people so far. The state-revenue board projects fifteen to twenty thousand refugees within four weeks if the situation does not stabilise.

Dvadashashringa listens. He says: "Court X, please initiate emergency-relief deliberations. Court III, please prepare a contingency funding analysis. Court XII, please open a cross-border grain-procurement file."

Three court-chiefs nod.

He does not yet know — he could not yet know — that he has just made a small organisational decision that will kill forty thousand people.

Three weeks later. The famine has worsened. Refugees in Bhopal are now twelve thousand. Court X is in week three of its disaster-relief deliberations — the disaster-relief statute's 2007 narrow-scope problem has emerged exactly as Court X's chief justice feared it would. Court III is in week three of arguing about whether to draw from the contingency reserve or pass an emergency revenue measure. Court XII is in week three of a 1981 cross-border-trade memorandum dispute.

Four other courts have, in the meantime, taken up some aspect of the famine. Court I (the new refugee camps' land-status), Court VII (refugee-as-temporary versus refugee-as-permanent classification), Court VI (whether temple grain-stores can be opened), and Court XI (Kanha's barasingha herds, who are also starving).

At the start of the fourth week, a senior dharmic counsellor presents himself at the assembly hall's ceremonial entrance. He has been invited by three of the chief justices to provide neutral arbitration. His name is Adharma-Kendra. He is fifty-three. He wears a plain ochre dhoti and shawl. He carries no staff and no entourage. He is welcomed.

Dvadashashringa recognises him. He stands. He says, evenly: "Uncle. You have come to the wrong meeting."

Adharma-Kendra smiles. The smile is genuine. He says: "Nephew. I have come to the meeting your wisest judges asked me to come to. They wrote to me. I have their letters in my satchel. I am not here to vote. I am here to abstain. There is a difference."

He turns to the assembly. He bows to each of the twelve courts in turn — the formal twelve-fold bow that has not been performed in this hall since the system's founding. The eleven judges who do not know what Dvadashashringa knows are deeply impressed. The one judge who has read his Chapter-One file — Aranya-Devi, Court XI, the forest-and-wildlife chief — is not impressed; but Aranya-Devi has been overruled on her own court's narrower question already this morning and is not in a position to overrule a procedural welcome.

Adharma-Kendra is admitted as a neutral senior counsellor with abstain-only voting privileges across all twelve courts.

Within forty-eight hours every court has cited him in support of continued deliberation. Within a week every court has slowed by another fifteen percent. The argument is always the same — the senior counsellor advises caution; let us deliberate more fully. Adharma-Kendra has not voted once. He has not needed to.

By the end of October the refugees in Bhopal number twenty-eight thousand. Court X is in week six of disaster-relief deliberations. The first famine-deaths are reported from a small village called Kunwariya in the Damoh district — eleven adults and four children in a single week.

Dvadashashringa reads the Kunwariya report on a Friday morning. He calls a private meeting with the chief justices of Courts X, III, and XII. He says: "What is the legal minimum decision-time required to authorise an emergency food convoy?"

Court X's chief justice (a careful woman of sixty-two) says: "Court X cannot authorise. The disaster-relief statute is scope-narrow. Court X can only authorise emergency-shelter and emergency-medical."

Court III's chief justice (a sixty-eight-year-old former finance secretary): "Court III cannot draw from contingency without Court X authorisation, which is scope-narrow as above. An emergency revenue measure requires bicameral assent — minimum three-week procedural cycle. Currently in week three of bicameral consultation."

Court XII (a thoughtful fifty-eight-year-old former diplomat): "Court XII cannot purchase grain abroad without contingency-reserve activation or revenue-measure passage. Currently in 1981 memorandum dispute, week six."

Dvadashashringa says: "What if I invoke royal prerogative?"

The three chief justices look at each other.

Court X says: "Maharaj. You founded this system to prevent royal prerogative. The founding charter forbids prerogative-invocation except in war."

"Is this not war?"

Court III, after a long pause: "It is a famine."

"Forty people are dead this week."

Court XII: "Famine, Maharaj. Not war."

He looks at them. They are not wrong. They are not even slightly wrong by the system he built. They are the best judges in central India. They are paralysed because his system is what made them so.

He says, finally: "Continue your deliberations."

He returns to the central observer-king seat. He does not sleep that night.

The Kunwariya report is the first one Sutrakara reads end-to-end. She is twelve. She has been sitting in the gallery of the Twelve-Court Assembly Hall since she was eight, mostly drawing diagrams of judges' speech-patterns in the margin of her grandfather's old arithmetic textbook. Her mother is dead (six years ago, an aneurysm). Her father is a king. She has been raised by court tutors and the gallery's sixty-year-old usher Mrs Bhattacharji, who lets her read official documents because Mrs Bhattacharji believes children should know the truth.

Sutrakara reads the Kunwariya report. She turns the page. She finds the village-by-village statistical annex Court X's clerk has compiled but not yet circulated to the chief justices. She reads the annex. She is twelve and she has been doing differential mathematics since she was nine. She runs the death-rate-curve forward against the deliberation-timeline.

The number she gets is forty thousand dead by the time the courts conclude. She runs it again. She gets the same number. She runs it a third time with conservative assumptions. She gets thirty-eight thousand.

She writes her calculation in clean ink on the back of three blank case-folder pages. She brings the pages to her father's study that evening.

He is preparing arguments for the next morning's court session. He looks at the pages. He says: "Beta. This is excellent arithmetic. The courts will reach their conclusions. The numbers cannot drive the dharma."

She says: "Pita-shri, the numbers are the dharma. Forty thousand people are the dharma. The courts are how we make sure no one person can be wrong. The dharma is something else."

He says, gently: "It is bedtime."

She says, more quietly: "I will speak to the chief justice tomorrow."

He nods. He thinks she means she will request an audience. He returns to his arguments.

The next morning she does not request an audience. She walks into the assembly hall during open session, climbs the gallery steps to the gallery's lowest railing, and asks Mrs Bhattacharji for the microphone-relay. Mrs Bhattacharji — who has been waiting for some child to do something like this for thirty years — hands her the microphone-relay.

She speaks. Her voice carries into the chamber. The twelve courts pause.

"Senior judges, I have run the famine-mortality curve against the deliberation-timeline. The current curve shows thirty-eight thousand to forty-four thousand dead by the time the courts conclude on their current procedural pace. I have brought death certificates from forty-seven villages. The certificates are below. Please look at them."

She drops the pile of certificates over the railing. They fall into the chamber. The certificates are real — she has collected them through Court X's clerk, who has been quietly grateful for someone to give them to.

Court XI's chief justice — Aranya-Devi — rises. She says: "I move that this assembly consider the young lady's evidence and accelerate deliberations accordingly."

Adharma-Kendra rises. He speaks softly. He says: "Senior judges. I am not voting today — I do not vote — but I will offer one observation. The numbers cannot dictate dharma. The courts must reach their natural conclusions. To act on raw numbers is to abandon dharmic process for utilitarian panic. I move — with humility, since I have no vote — that the assembly thank the young lady for her diligence and continue the deliberations."

The motion is taken. Aranya-Devi votes against. Adharma-Kendra abstains. The other ten chief justices vote for. The motion passes ten-to-one with one abstention.

Sutrakara puts the microphone-relay back in Mrs Bhattacharji's hand. She walks out of the gallery without saying a further word.

Dvadashashringa finds her in the corridor outside the gallery. She is crying with her back to a sandstone column. Her face is wet but she is not making a sound — she is twelve and she has been raised in court galleries; she knows how to cry quietly.

He kneels in front of her. He does not touch her.

She says: "Pita-shri, the courts will not save them. The courts cannot save them. They will all be dead by the time the courts agree."

He says: "The courts are how we know what is right."

She wipes her face with the back of her wrist. She looks at him in the way only a daughter can look at a father in a corridor.

She says: "No. The courts are how we make sure no one person can be wrong. The dharma is something else. The dharma is what gets done. The courts do not do anything. The courts decide whether something done is correct. If nothing is done there is nothing for the courts to decide whether is correct. The courts have made themselves unnecessary."

He does not answer for a long time.

She says, more softly: "I read the Bhimbetka paintings with Aaji last summer. Thirty thousand years of people. The paintings never show twelve judges deciding. The paintings show one person who saw the danger and acted. The dharma is in the acting."

He stands up. He looks down the corridor. The hall's twelve doors are at exact thirty-degree intervals. The corridor he is standing in is at one of those intervals. He has been standing in this corridor for twenty-two months without noticing it.

He says, finally: "Go home, beta. I will come for dinner. There is a thing I need to walk to the Narmada about."

She nods. She walks home.

He walks to the Narmada at dusk.

The Narmada river runs west across central India — the only major Indian river that runs east-to-west, against the geography. Dvadashashringa has always thought of this as a small but useful daily reminder that what looks like the necessary direction is not always the direction. He has not paid attention to the reminder.

He sits on the riverbank at the Bhojeshwar Temple stone-platform. The temple itself — an unfinished eleventh-century Shiva temple, one of central India's great medieval ruins — sits behind him. He watches the river.

The water ripples in a pattern that is not the current. He has been at this riverbank for six years. He has never seen this pattern. The pattern is a face.

The face is Sage Vidyanaraya. The spirit-guru of Karnataka. The one who appears in moving water from the Tungabhadra and now — for the third time in three months — from the Ganga and now from the Narmada. The cross-kingdom visits are themselves the message.

Dvadashashringa reads the ripples.

Cousin. The Yudhishtira who matters is not the one who answered every question. The Yudhishtira who matters is the one who let his brother burn his palace down because the palace had become a cage.

Dvadashashringa says, aloud, to the water: "If I dissolve the courts I violate my own founding principle."

If you do not dissolve the courts you violate the lives the courts are killing. There is no dharma without one of those violations. The dharma is the one you choose.

"My uncle will say I have abandoned dharmic process."

Your uncle has been abandoning dharmic process for forty years by staying perfectly still. You will know it tomorrow because the man hunted south from Lucknow is coming to your court.

He looks up sharply. He says: "Drona-of-the-Plain?"

Drona-of-the-Plain. He has the proof.

The face is gone. The river is just the river. The barasingha-mark on his chest pulses once, low.

He walks home. Sutrakara is waiting at the dinner table with bhutta-roti and mahua-pickle and the day's second arithmetic-notebook. He eats. He talks to her. He does not tell her what he is going to do in the morning.

He arrives at the side-gate at three a.m. He is sixty-seven years old. He has been on the road for nineteen days — travelling by train, by bus, by farmer's truck, by foot for the last forty kilometres because he saw Adharma-Kendra's men at the Bhopal railway station. His grey hair is uncut. His travel-coat is dust-coloured.

He carries a leather satchel. The satchel contains: (1) photographs of Adharma-Kendra meeting with Adharma of Banaras in a Mumbai hotel six weeks before the Karnataka throne-stone destruction; (2) bank transfer records showing the same Singapore-routed account funded both the Karnataka Restoration Charter publication and the Mormugao port consortium's lobby budget; (3) a memorandum — written in Adharma-Kendra's own hand — outlining a coordination strategy across the Bloodline-B fault line. The memorandum is the proof.

Dvadashashringa receives him in the small east study. He reads the memorandum three times. He says: "How did you obtain this."

Drona-of-the-Plain says: "A junior secretary in Adharma-Kendra's Mumbai office is my late wife's cousin's son. He has been worried for some time. I asked. He gave."

"Will you testify."

"I owe forty years of straightening. I will testify."

Dvadashashringa pours two cups of mahua-tea from the silver pot. He says: "The assembly meets at nine. I will dissolve the twelve courts before lunch. You will testify in the recess. Stay in the small east study until I send for you."

Drona-of-the-Plain says: "Maharaj. I am sorry I waited this long."

"You did not wait. You came when you could. Drink the tea."

The Twelve-Court Assembly Hall opens at nine sharp. The twelve chief justices take their seats. Adharma-Kendra takes his neutral-counsellor seat. Sutrakara is in the gallery again — Mrs Bhattacharji is in her usual spot. Aranya-Devi (Court XI, the forest-and-wildlife chief) makes eye contact with Sutrakara and nods once.

Dvadashashringa enters carrying the Dwadash twelve-pronged staff in both hands — not diagonally across his lap as he usually carries it; held in both hands across his body. He is wearing the twelve-pointed crown.

He climbs to the central observer-king seat. He does not sit. He stands in front of the seat. He removes the twelve-pointed crown and places it on the teakwood stand. He turns. He faces the twelve courts.

He says: "I founded the twelve-court system at the start of my reign because I believed twelve sides of every question were better than one side. I was right then. I am wrong now. The court system was designed for the normal questions of land, marriage, taxation, succession, water-rights, religious sites, caste honour, refugee status, commerce, disaster scope, wildlife, and cross-border trade. It was not designed for a famine. The famine has killed two thousand four hundred people while we have argued whether refugee-status is temporary or permanent. The dharma is not in the deliberation. The dharma is in the feeding. I cannot dissolve the famine. I can dissolve the courts."

He lifts the Dwadash staff. He swings it once in an arc above his head — the ceremonial preparation-arc. The twelve solar-gold prong-tips catch the sandstone-filtered morning light.

He strikes the floor of the assembly chamber.

The first strike rings off the sandstone. Court I, Land & Inheritance, dissolves.

He strikes again. Court II, Marriage & Family.

Strike. Court III, Tax & Revenue.

Strike. Court IV, Commerce & Hoarding.

Strike. Court V, Tribal & Adivasi.

Strike. Court VI, Religious Sites.

Strike. Court VII, Citizenship & Refugee.

Strike. Court VIII, Inter-State Water.

On the eighth strike the Dwadash staff cracks. The crack runs the length of the shaft — he feels it through his hands more than he hears it.

He does not stop.

Strike. Court IX, Caste & Honour.

Strike. Court X, Disaster Relief. (The chief justice of Court X, the careful woman of sixty-two, weeps openly.)

Strike. Court XI, Forest & Wildlife. (Aranya-Devi sits straight in her seat with both hands on her armrests.)

On the eleventh strike the staff splits into two pieces in his right hand. The lower piece falls. He picks it up with his left hand. He continues.

Strike. Court XII, Cross-Border Trade.

On the twelfth strike the lower piece breaks in his left hand. The Dwadash twelve-pronged staff is now in three pieces on the sandstone floor of the assembly chamber. Twelve solar-gold prong-tips are scattered across the stone.

Dvadashashringa says: "The dharma is not in my staff. The dharma is in the act of breaking it."

The hall is silent. The chief justices are stunned. Adharma-Kendra rises slowly. He keeps his voice gentle.

"Nephew. You have just destroyed three thousand years of dharmic governance because a child showed you a number."

"I have destroyed twelve courts that could not decide whether to feed forty-seven villages. The dharma was in the feeding. The dharma was not in the courts."

"You will be judged for this."

"I am the judge. I am dissolving that too. From this hour the kingdom of Hridaya-Sthana operates under emergency single-court governance. The single judge is me. The single advisor is my daughter Sutrakara. The administrative deputies are: Aranya-Devi of former Court XI as deputy chief justice; the chief justices of former Courts III, X, and XII as regional governors of central, northern, and southern Madhya Pradesh respectively. The other eight courts' chief justices may submit resignations or take administrative postings at their discretion. The famine-relief convoys leave Bhopal in forty-eight hours."

Adharma-Kendra opens his mouth. Dvadashashringa raises his right hand.

"I am not finished. I have one more matter. The neutral senior counsellor admitted to this assembly in week three has been engineering the deliberation paralysis on purpose. I have the proof."

He turns his head slightly. Drona-of-the-Plain steps out from behind the central pillar where he has been waiting for thirty-one minutes. He carries the leather satchel.

He walks to the centre of the chamber. He stands beside Dvadashashringa.

He says, with the same plain steadiness he used at the Imambara: "Honourable judges. My name is Drona-of-the-Plain. I am the senior dharmic scholar of three Bloodline-B kingdoms. I owe Adharma-Kendra a forty-year debt for the saving of my maternal uncle's life. I have, until last month, allowed that debt to tilt my counsel in his favour. Last month at the Lucknow Bara Imambara I gave testimony that reversed the tilt. He has hunted me south since. I am here this morning because the evidence in this satchel proves what the Maharaj has just said. I will display the evidence."

He opens the satchel. He places the photographs on the assembly's evidence-table. He places the bank records beside them. He places the handwritten memorandum on top.

He says: "The handwriting on this memorandum is Adharma-Kendra's. Three of the eleven of you have ruled on cases where his handwriting was the central exhibit. You will recognise it."

The three chief justices stand up to look at the memorandum. They look. They sit down slowly.

Court IX's chief justice — an older man named Patwardhan-ji who has known Adharma-Kendra socially for thirty years — says, with visible difficulty: "It is his hand."

Adharma-Kendra is no longer in his seat. The senior-counsellor's seat is empty. The side-door of the chamber — the one Adharma-Kendra entered through three weeks ago when the assembly welcomed him — is slightly ajar.

He is gone.

Aranya-Devi sends three Court XI staff after him within ninety seconds. They do not catch him. The Bhopal police are alerted by 11:00. By 14:00 he has been sighted in the Bhopal old quarter near the Taj-ul-Masajid mosque. By 18:00 he has not been sighted again. He surfaces three days later in a small village outside Sehore and disappears. He survives the chapter intact.

Dvadashashringa stands at the centre of the assembly chamber with the broken Dwadash staff at his feet. The eleven chief justices, ashamed, sit in their seats. The hall is silent for a long minute. Sutrakara is in the gallery with both hands gripping the railing.

He feels the barasingha-mark pulse through his chest. The half-body Stage III stroke forms — the antler-curve crossing from sternum to shoulder, the foreleg extending across the ribcage. But the mark forms cracked. There is a visible scar through the centre of the antler-curve — a single line of skin where the bond's ink does not settle. The mark records, in the bond's own writing, what the dissolution cost.

He looks down at the cracked mark. He says quietly, to himself: "So we will carry this."

The Indian Paradise Flycatcher — MP's sacred bird, with its two impossibly long tail feathers — flies in through the assembly's open ceiling vent and lands on Sutrakara's shoulder in the gallery. The bird's tail-feathers trail down past her knees. The bird sings

once. The Stage I hoofprint — the daughter's own first mark — will form on her upper back over the next week. She is not yet a hero. She is the kingdom's witness.

The famine-relief convoys leave Bhopal forty-six hours after the dissolution. The first convoy reaches Damoh-Kunwariya the following Monday with twelve trucks of rice and chickpea-flour. Local volunteers distribute. The Kunwariya headman — whose name is Lakhan Singh, sixty-one — weeps when the first sack of rice is opened.

Over the next eight weeks the death-count rises to forty-seven thousand before slowing. The single emergency-court resolves a hundred and fourteen cases in those eight weeks — more than the twelve-court system resolved in the preceding six. Aranya-Devi is appointed deputy chief justice on the third day and is by week six effectively running daily operations. Vidura-Babu of UP sends two of his best Awadhi administrators on day three of the dissolution; they arrive in Bhopal with a written note from Gangaputra (delivered by Sarus Crane carrier — the network is back in operation).

The note says: Brother. I heard you broke the staff. I heard you broke the courts. I broke a crown last month. We seem to be in the breaking business. Vidura-Babu sends his two best administrators. Send word when you need more. Tell Sutrakara her cousin Yamunadatta will write to her when his calligraphy improves. — G.

Dvadashashringa reads the note. He laughs for the first time in nine weeks. He passes the note to Sutrakara. She reads it. She does not laugh, but she smiles. She begins drafting a reply that night. The reply takes her four days because her calligraphy is already excellent and she wants to make sure Yamunadatta's is up to the standard.

Two weeks after the dissolution. Kanha National Park, north-east of Mandla. A herd of sixty barasingha — one of the larger surviving herds in the park — is reported by a junior forest-guard as standing motionless in a clearing south of the Sonf meadow.

The guard reports it on Monday morning. By Tuesday afternoon it has not moved. By Wednesday it has not moved. By Sunday it has not moved.

The herd is unhurt. The animals are not in visible distress — their breathing is normal, their eyes track moving objects, they are not dehydrated. They are simply not doing what grazing animals do. They are facing east. They are standing.

By the seventh day the news has reached Bhopal. Aranya-Devi sends a telegram to Dvadashashringa: Maharaj. Court XI matter that no longer exists. Herd not behaving. Will

you visit?

He goes alone. He drives the eight hours from Bhopal himself, in an old Mahindra he keeps because his father kept the same model. He arrives at the Sonf meadow on the herd's ninth motionless day.

The herd is exactly as the guard reported. Sixty animals, antlers raised, facing east. The morning mist is lifting off the meadow. The animals stand in the mist as if they were carved.

Dvadashashringa walks to the centre of the herd. The animals do not flinch. He has the barasingha-bond — the only person in the kingdom strong enough in the bond to read what they are doing.

He reads it.

The herd has been caught in the gap between knowing-the-question and answering-it. They sensed the famine. They sensed the courts arguing. They began to ask, in the herd's collective sense, what to do. The asking did not arrive at an answer because the kingdom's answering-mechanism — the twelve courts — had broken. They have been frozen in the middle of asking for eleven days.

The Void Maw lives in that gap. The Maw is what arrives when the asking and the answering separate too far. The herd has not been taken; they have been paused.

On the twelfth day, late in the afternoon, one of the barasingha lowers her head and begins to graze. The others follow within ten minutes. None of them remembers the eleven days. The pause-time is a blank in the herd's behavioural memory — visible through the bond as an empty interval.

Dvadashashringa orders a small shrine built at the southern edge of the clearing. Sandstone and packed earth. A single barasingha-antler carved in low relief on the eastern face — the direction the herd had been facing. The Kanha forest guards become the shrine's keepers. The shrine remains.

A month after the herd returned to grazing. Bhimbetka — the rock-shelter site forty kilometres south of Bhopal, where central Indian people painted on stone for thirty-five thousand years.

Dvadashashringa takes Sutrakara to Bhimbetka on her thirteenth birthday. They climb up to Shelter III — the one with the famous hunter-and-bull painting, the one their family has

visited four times since Sutrakara was six.

They sit on the stone bench inside Shelter III. The painting is on the wall in front of them — a single hunter, painted in red ochre, facing a single bull, painted in white. The hunter holds a spear. The bull's horns are forward. The painting is eight thousand years old by the conservative dating, twelve thousand by the unconservative.

He says: "You were right. The painting shows one person acting."

She looks at it. She has looked at it eight or ten times in her life and she has thought about it carefully every time.

She says: "Pita-shri. The painting also shows the bull. The bull is the famine. The hunter is you. The hunter is alone but the painting was made by a tribe. The tribe is what remembers. The tribe is what painted. The painting is older than the hunter and older than the bull. The painting is what makes the act dharmic instead of just an act."

He looks at her. She is thirteen as of this morning. The Indian Paradise Flycatcher — the one that landed on her shoulder at the assembly dissolution, the one with the impossibly long tail feathers — has followed them to Bhimbetka. The bird is perched on the stone-shelter's ledge above the painting. The bird does not sing. The bird listens.

He puts his arm around her. She leans into him. She has been twelve and she is now thirteen and she has been correct about the hunter and the bull and the tribe in the same paragraph.

He says: "I will carry the broken staff into every Council session. I will not have it repaired."

"Good."

"You will sit beside me at every Council session."

"I know."

"You will be twelve again in three more sessions and then you will be thirteen again."

She smiles. The wordplay is one of theirs — old, comfortable, mathematician's wordplay about how she will always have been twelve in the same way her father will always have been forty-six in the moment of dissolution. The mark on his chest will always be cracked. The painting will always be eight thousand years old in the conservative dating.

The bird sings — one short note, the call of the Indian Paradise Flycatcher that birders write down as tszip-twee. The note is very small in the size of Bhimbetka's rock-shelters. The note is very large in the size of the chapter.

Twelve thousand kilometres away — or at any rate considerably south — in Kanha National Park, sixty barasingha graze.

The Pilot's Closing Image

A father and a thirteen-year-old daughter sitting on a stone bench inside an eight-thousand-year-old rock shelter. A red-ochre hunter facing a white bull on the wall. An Indian Paradise Flycatcher on the stone-shelter ledge above the painting, its two impossibly long tail-feathers trailing past the rock's edge. The barasingha-mark cracked on the father's chest. The Dwadash staff in three pieces wrapped in saffron cloth at his feet. The tribe that painted the painting gone for eight thousand years but visible in every red-ochre line. The hunter is alone but the painting was made by a tribe. The tribe is what remembers. The tribe is what painted. The painting is what makes the act dharmic instead of just an act.